

Chapter 6

Instructor's Manual

This chapter covers:

- An introduction to the school and the teacher as major forces in the perpetuation of language ideology
- The instructional goals of the school in regards to literacy and standard language ideology
- How the notions of appropriacy and communicative competence can be connected to linguistic discrimination in education
- The arguments that many educators have for why children should be taught *SAE
- The effects of appropriacy arguments on speakers of devalued language varieties
- A discussion of language policy in education from the mid-nineteenth century to the present
- The educational policies and social expectations related to teachers' speech
- Studies examining university students' reaction to L2 accents in teaching assistants and lecturers
- A few examples of schools and educators who resist the standard language subordination process

Sample answers to the questions from the text and the website

From the textbook

1. Write your own linguistic history. Where did your influences come from? What ideologies were you exposed to? Which did you accept, and to what degree? Have you studied any foreign languages? Do you feel as though you could survive in a country where that language is spoken? What would it take?

Sample answer: My linguistic influences came from both home and school, and the language ideologies I was exposed to at these two places were very similar. I grew up as a native speaker of a valued dialect of English, and I subconsciously accepted the ideology that privileges my dialect over others. I say subconsciously because, while I have considered *SAE to be the “most correct” variety of English, I have never consciously thought that my own variety of English (which I imagine most people would say was pretty close to *SAE) was better than another person's variety of English.

However, while I have grown up speaking a valued variety of English, my accent and general abilities in the foreign languages I have studied would make it tough for me to survive in a foreign country. I have studied Spanish, Japanese, and Mandarin. My Mandarin would be pretty incomprehensible since I have such a tough time with tones – my Mandarin-speaking friends have a very hard time understanding me, and I think the only person I can really communicate with in Mandarin is my teacher. My Spanish and Japanese are much better in terms of grammar and pronunciation. I think I could get by with my Spanish or Japanese in a foreign country, but I

imagine it would be exhausting for me to have to speak those languages all the time and continuously work to be understood.

2. Do you have any memories of being corrected for the way you said something? Who did the correcting? What reason was given, and how did you react? Anger? Shame? Confusion?

Sample answer: I have been corrected a few times on the way I pronounced names or words I had only seen in print and had never heard pronounced. This is a very minor thing to be corrected on, but even so it was embarrassing because the friends and teachers who corrected me seemed to think it was funny that I had pronounced those words the way I had, and my incorrect pronunciation served as a shibboleth to indicate I was not experienced in that field.

3. Describe your own experiences in school. Were there speakers of stigmatized varieties of English in your classroom? Were you one of those speakers? How did perceptions make things easier or harder for them (or you)?

Sample answer: In my school in northern California, there were a few people with L2 accents who were first language Spanish speakers and there were some speakers of Chicano English. There were also some students who had a “country” accent, for lack of a better word. The people with the “country” accent typically hung out with the “cowboy” social clique. The “skater” clique had another way of talking that sounded like what I would call a “surfer dialect.” I hung out with some of the “skaters” in high school, and would use some lexical items and pronunciations in informal situations or when hanging out with that group. I never heard anybody correct people from any of these groups on their spoken language use, but I think there were certain negative associations with these varieties. In my school, there were negative stereotypes about the academic achievement of all of these groups – no group was considered to be outright unintelligent, but there were no stereotypes about members of these groups (or people who speak like them) being particularly smart. This negative stereotype probably made it harder for members of these groups to be taken as seriously by the teachers, which may have made school more difficult or may have even helped create a self-fulfilling prophecy of underachievement in school.

4. Search online in communities that discuss education and look for terms such as “standard English,” “non-standard English,” “dialect,” “grammar,” and “ugly.” Was it easy or hard to find discussions of the issues covered in this chapter? What trends (if any) did you come across?

Sample answer: It was not very difficult to find discussions related to standard and non-standard varieties in the classroom. A search of the forums for Dave’s ESL Café (<http://www.eslcafe.com/>) and UsingEnglish.com (<http://www.usingenglish.com/>) revealed a mix of reactions to this topic. Some people clearly bought in to the language subordination process and believed that devalued varieties were not fit for the classroom. However, a surprising number of people who responded to these threads championed typically devalued language varieties, bringing up linguistic facts about variation and the connection between linguistic discrimination and other underlying forms of discrimination.

5. Interview a friend who has never taken a linguistics class. Ask that person for definitions of “standard” and “non-standard” English, and be sure to ask for examples. Don't give away your thoughts or reactions, just record what your informant has to say, no matter how much you agree or disagree. Compare your findings with others in the class.

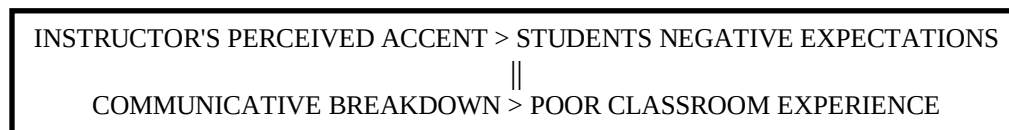
Sample answer: My friend defined these terms as follows:

Standard English: the English that we are taught to use in school.

Non-standard English: the improper English that uneducated people use.

When I asked her for examples of people who speak standard English, she said that teachers and news reporters speak “proper English.” When I asked her who speaks non-standard English, she said: “Anybody who hasn’t had a good education probably speaks non-standard English. For example, people living way out in the boonies probably speak non-standard English, and so would most people living in the inner city.” I find it interesting that she focused in on both the rural and the urban poor as people who would not have a “good education” and therefore don’t speak “proper English.”

6. Consider this diagram:



How accurate do you think this is? What might be missing?

Sample answer: I think this diagram is pretty accurate for the classroom context; however, it does not take into account the social forces from outside the classroom that allow students to justify their choice to abandon their portion of the communicative burden. Also, it does not account for the students who *do* keep up their half of the communicative burden and work to understand an instructor’s accent. In addition, since one study found that perception of accent was at least in part based upon a student’s expectations for what grade he or she would receive in the course, I think something about the overall interest in or aptitude for a course would also be a relevant factor.

7. Have the materials in this chapter raised questions for you? Doubts? Do you feel the same way you did before this course on matters of language in the classroom?

Sample answer: After this chapter, I feel torn about how I feel about teaching *SAE. Before reading this chapter and taking this course, I felt very confident that all children should learn *SAE in order to have an equal chance at economic opportunities in the future. Now I realize that that argument has some serious flaws, but it is still difficult for me to abandon that idea. I am also wondering what a solution to this could be – will there always be some language variety that is held up as a standard? Would educating students on the legitimacy of each variety and

explaining that society chooses a standard based on what the people in power speak help break the cycle of linguistic subordination?

8. *Write a short list of guidelines you might go over with a biology class where all of the teaching assistants are non-native speakers of English. How can the students contribute to making communication work? Are there concrete steps to take when communication breaks down?*

Sample answer: First, I would explain to the students how difficult it is to shed an L2 accent completely, and I would ask the students to let the teaching assistant know when they can't understand him/her. When this happens, the students can politely ask the teaching assistant to repeat what s/he said, or rephrase the utterance in a different way, or even write down a word that the students are having a hard time understanding. If the students (and the teaching assistant) are patient, they will be able to resolve any miscommunications that arise. I would also recommend that students try to visit their teaching assistant during office hours so they will have more exposure to the TA's accent. This way, they can get extra help in the class and can become more familiar with the TA's English pronunciation, which will make it easier for the students to understand the teaching assistant (and perhaps other teaching assistants with similar accents) in the future.

9. *Interview a graduate teaching assistant or a professor or instructor who speaks English with a strong accent of any kind that contrasts with the average person on campus. For example, someone with a strong Texas accent teaching in northern California, or someone whose first language is Japanese teaching in Cincinnati. Ask what experiences they have had because of accent. Positive, negative, neutral?*

Sample answer: I interviewed a Korean teaching assistant who helped teach the political science class I took last fall. He said that most students are neutral to his accent, but he has had some problems. He had one student in his first semester as a teaching assistant who would interrupt class by making loud comments to her neighbor about how she couldn't understand what the teaching assistant had just said rather than asking him to clarify anything for her. That was his most problematic student, but he has had others who were more polite but clearly frustrated by frequent miscommunications. He said that he tried to help those students, but he felt that most of them just didn't put out any effort to understand him or the material in that class. He has also had other students that had trouble understanding him at times, but they would raise their hands in class and ask him to explain a topic again rather than interrupting or getting frustrated. He said that these students were easier to work with and he was usually able to resolve any miscommunications with them.

From the website

Audio

1. *Listen to the samples of Appalachian English, British West Indian English, Sea Islands Creole, Gullah, Mexicano English, and Hawai'i Creole English. What kind of experiences do you imagine speakers of these varieties would have in a classroom that focused on *SAE?*

Sample Answer: Since these varieties of English differ from *SAE, speakers of these varieties will most likely be victims of the language subordination process in which educators and policy makers will devalue their language variety and try to convince them to devalue it as well. In addition, these speakers will most likely be pressured to learn to speak *SAE in order to assimilate to the dominant social group instead of questioning the linguistic status quo.

2. Listen to the samples of Hawai'ian Creole English and AAVE. Do you think it would be inappropriate for a law student to ask a question in class using these language varieties? Why or why not?

Sample Answer: I think that most people would be startled to hear a law student asking a question in class using Hawai'ian Creole English or a variety of AAVE that is very different from *SAE because of notions of what language variety is appropriate in this particular context. However, while it may be surprising for people because they expect *SAE in this context, there is no reason why a student could not ask a question in Hawai'ian Creole English or AAVE. Both language varieties are well equipped to discuss matters of law, just like *SAE.

3. Listen to the samples of South Carolinian English and Spanish-accented English. Then revisit the quotes from actual speakers of these varieties on page 91. How do these speakers' comments fit in with this chapter's discussion of language subordination and the appropriacy argument?

Sample Answer: These accents differ from *SAE, so speakers with these accents may very well be pressured by the educational system to change their speech in order to get ahead in a society that values *SAE. Both of the speakers who were quoted on page 91 have accepted the standard language ideology that devalues their accents and urges them to adopt the "superior" *SAE. They both feel uncomfortable with the way they speak and feel like they should "improve" their accents.

4. Listen to the samples of speakers with Greek, Bostonian, Alabaman, Japanese, Cantonese, and other Asian accents. These accents were all relevant to the discussions of whether teachers with foreign accents or devalued L1 accents should be allowed to teach children and college students' reactions to instructors and teaching assistants with accents. Do you think people with these accents should be allowed to teach young children? Do you think people with these accents should be allowed to teach at the university level? Explain why you feel the way you do. Can you back up your opinions with research that supports your position?

Sample Answer: Yes, I think people with any accent should be able to teach at any level. If the teacher is proficient enough in English to get through the interview process and be understood, then the teacher can also be understood by his or her students. Instead of worrying that children might pick up a devalued accent from a teacher (which is very unlikely since children have pretty much dialed in their language variety/varieties by the time they begin attending school), parents and educational policy makers should worry about the underlying discrimination that causes them to worry about that issue in the first place. At the university level, research shows that students are often biased in their perception of instructor accents and also showed bias against instructors with accents. This research tells me that a major part of communication problems

between students and international teaching assistants lies with the students rather than the teaching assistant.

Video

“Fox News and Black English – Ebonics”

From *Fox News Chicago*, posted on Garrard McClendon’s website:

http://web.mac.com/igarrard/Black_English/Ax_or_Ask.html

This video clip provides material for discussion of the educational system as a major force in the language subordination system.

1. How does the content of this video illustrate the language subordination process and appropriacy arguments around standard and non-standard dialects?

Sample Answer: This video illustrates the language subordination process in several ways. For example, the news story presents African American English as being “improper” English. Garrard McClendon criticizes parents and teachers for not correcting the “improper” aspects of AAVE that children use. Once it has been established that AAVE is “improper” English, McClendon warns the children that interviewers will be listening to the way they speak, which could affect their future employment. In this way, McClendon makes the argument that AAVE is not appropriate for formal contexts such as job interviews. The students accept this argument, as revealed in the interview with a female student about half-way through the video who says that in her area, “we talk slang, we don’t talk proper English at all.” This statement shows that this student believes in the standard language ideology that devalues her language variety.

*2. Chapter 6 discusses two main reasons to justify teaching *SAE to schoolchildren. What are those two arguments, and which one does Garrard McClendon support?*

Sample Answer: The first main argument to justify teaching *SAE to schoolchildren is based on economic factors. Supporters of this argument believe students must master *SAE in order to be able to get a good job and prosper economically. The other main argument is based on the idea that non-*SAE dialects are deficient, so children need to be taught *SAE so they can think clearly. McClendon is focused on the first argument. He encourages African American students to study and use *SAE grammar so they won’t slip through the cracks of the economy because of their speech.

Suggested activities and discussion questions

1. Ask the students if they think *SAE should be taught in schools. What arguments can they think of in support of teaching *SAE in schools? What arguments can they think of in opposition to teaching *SAE in schools? How do the students feel about teaching *SAE in schools?

2. Ask your class to consider the following question posed in Chapter 6 (page 88):

If by magic it were possible to make every school-aged child in the nation instantaneously bilingual, equally proficient in English and in their native language, would the problem of discrimination in the schools go away?

What answers do the students have for this question? Ask them to explain why they feel the way they do.

3. Ask the students if they have ever had a teacher with a foreign accent. What grade were they in when they had this teacher? What impact do they think that teacher's accent had on the quality of his or her class? Do they feel any differently about these teachers after reading this chapter?

4. Have the students interview their friends or classmates in other courses about their opinions regarding college professors and teaching assistants with L2 accents. Encourage the students to ask for examples to explain why their interviewees feel the way they do. After collecting data, ask the students to reflect upon their results in writing or with their classmates.

5. Find out which students have children or want to have children in the future. Ask these students if they want their children to learn *SAE in school and why they feel the way they do. What would your students think about their children having a teacher with a devalued accent?

6. To enhance discussion of this chapter, please visit the companion website and check out the audio and video clips available for use in your classroom.